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You are nearing 30; you refuse to admit you are balding; your skills and qualifications include Martial arts, breakdancing, chess, channel surfing, people skills and a Bachelor of Fine Arts from the College of Design, Los Angeles; you want to write scripts for Hollywood blockbuster flicks, but directors and producers just don't understand your need to eat!

"So that's the way it's going to be? Alright, if you can't join 'em, kill 'em! By the powers of Shaolin, I will avenge my dishonour!" You can actually *hire your very own personal Ninja assassin* at Ninja4Hire.com! Cool service, huh?

You throw down your Ninja ball-that-causes-much-smoke thingy, and disappear from public life—for a few days. You binge on certain banned substances, damage your brain, are forced into re-hab, and decide to reform yourself.

The plan takes shape gradually in your head, while you wait for the hallucinogens to wear off. You buy a domain, you boast about your achievements and talent, but the cincher is the fact that you are a Ninja—fast, silent, unseen; you can be in and out of a building before someone says "Ah So!"; you can fly, break boards with your bare hands, and have watched *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon* 6,872,345 times!

You offer to exact vengeance on behalf of those who are too chicken to do so themselves. You wait for the calls to come, for the hits on your Web site to soar, and your Inbox to fill up with death requests! Four years later, and you're still waiting.

Other hotels have also jumped on the iPod-serving bandwagon—Le Meridien



Cyberport in Hong Kong and the One & Only Ocean Club in the Bahamas.

INTERNET SUICIDE PACT

Seven Kill Themselves Over The Internet

According to a Reuters report, seven Japanese people are believed to have killed

themselves following an Internet suicide pact. The four men and three women were found in a car near Tokyo. They sealed the windows from the inside, and lit charcoal burners—then succumbed to carbon monoxide poisoning, which is the end-result of burning charcoal.

There are many Web sites that cater to Japan's chronically depressed. Services range from bringing together those wishing to die, to recommending the best locations to do it.

Police say that one of the seven sent an e-mail on October 11 to a friend declaring his intention to kill himself. A police spokesman said that they believed that the seven people "got acquainted through the Internet." Japanese Authorities report that since police became aware of Internet suicide pacts in early 2003, 34 people had died. It is a trend they would certainly want to stop. ☐

Blog WATCH

Here's taking a look at a few riveting posts from the world of blogs. This month, a serious look at the benign (?) lump on Dubya's back—in great detail; why an American was arrested in Belarus; a novel idea that seems obvious once you think of it—Bayesian spell-checkers; and Jonathan Schwartz' defence of Sun in re OpenOffice.org.

Jonathan Schwartz
<http://snipurl.com/9x3v>

Jonathan Schwartz defends Sun on OpenOffice.org

Here's some legal stuff. Dave Rosenberg posts on a ZDNet blog—<http://snipurl.com/9x3u>—"In what seems to be one of the more bizarre and confusing aspects of the unholy alliance between Sun and Microsoft, Sun's recent 10k filing includes previously unseen legalese from the settlement agreement." OpenOffice.org is important for Linux distros, and Sun seems to be abandoning it.

Sun's new position seems to create "the sort of legal uncertainty that could dampen corporate enthusiasm for one of desktop Linux' most promising open source projects as well as any Linux distros that are bundled with it." Read: Red Hat. And Rosenberg wonders what Jonathan Schwartz, Executive Vice-President of Software at Sun, has to say about this.

Schwartz' response is at the URL mentioned above. He implores, "Please do not listen to the bizarre numbskull anti-Sun conspiracy theorists."

David Weinberger
<http://snipurl.com/9x3w>

Bayesian Spell-checkers?

Now here's a bright idea. One of those "Why didn't we think of it before" ones. Weinberger talks about how we could have Bayesian spell-checkers, which would work just like Bayesian spam filters do. If it hasn't struck you yet: the word "cheat" is more likely to be corrected to "cheats" if used near the word "game," but if it's near the word "heart," say, it's more likely to be "chest."

Boing Boing
<http://snipurl.com/9x3y>

Arrested for providing VoIP!

Boing Boing has things ranging from news about a free tooth flosser to headlines like "What's happened to George W Bush's brain after 10 years?" One post we're looking at right now is about American citizen Ilya Mafter, who started a VoIP service in Belarus. He was arrested for "damage to the country's communication providers." Read about this at the URL mentioned above. There's lots of cool stuff on Boing Boing - for example, check out Mark Frauenfelder's links at <http://snipurl.com/9x40>, and John Battelle's beta "Thoughts on the intersection of search, media, technology, and more," at <http://snipurl.com/9x41>.

Anonymous
www.IsBushWired.com

Is Bush Wired? Is he prompted through an earpiece?

That's the headline on this cool blog, entirely devoted to finding out what the squarish lump on Dubya's back—seen during his first presidential debate on September 30—is. We don't know how long interest in this blog will last, though, but right now there's a lot of people gravitating to IsBushWired.com. Is Bush really wired, the blog asks. Posts discuss the entire range of theories. Generally, the site is of the opinion that Bush is indeed wired all the time. Head to IsBushWired for views by Secret Service Agents, prominent newspapers, technical experts, and so on, all on the same subject.